woman named Fauziyya Hassan, a friend of Mariam, in connection with what was now called the espionage case.

The first ISRO scientist whose name was dragged into the story was that of D Sasikumaran, my deputy in the cryogenic engine project, which I was heading. I was also the project director in charge of liquid propulsion systems.

As the ISRO spy story got raunchier by the day, we, a few close friends in the organisation, started discussing whether Sasikumaran actually had something to do with Mariam. But we all laughed at the espionage part of it. The reason was simple: India just did not have the know-how to make a cryogenic engine. There were of course several drawings and blueprints of the Vikas engine which we had developed over five years working with French space scientists, and those were routinely shared with Indian manufacturers. There was nothing classified which had to be smuggled. Anyone with a basic understanding of rocket science knows even if the drawings are given, an engine cannot be made without long years of development, guidance and extensive tests. In other words, you can't make a rocket engine based on know-how—you need the 'know-why'. If rockets were built merely with drawings, there is no reason why every space-faring nation is making rockets its own way and not copying from others.

My colleagues Mohana Prasad, M K Gopinathan Nair and I frequently spoke about the absurdities in the spy story the police and the newspapers were cooking up. Often we spoke on the phone. During one such conversation, I felt that my phone was being tapped, and immediately told Gopi, who was at the other end.

'How do you know?' he asked.

I told him there was a 'click' noise after which the volume dipped slightly—tell-tale signs of unsophisticated telephone tapping.

'Anyway, whoever is tapping, let him have fun. We have no secrets,' I said.

We carried on with our conversation. The more the stories of spying came out, the more convinced we were of the stupidity of the perpetrators, whoever they may be. But it ceased to be a laughing matter as police